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Merging colleges weigh past and future

Smaller schools seek to keep identity, solvency

By Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

For years, Hampshire College leaders were determined to preserve the institution as it was. Despite increasingly dire financial distress, they insisted on remaining independent and declined to explore options such as merging with a more stable school after an unpopular and failed attempt to do so in 2019.

Like other small troubled schools before it, Hampshire could not hold off the inevitable, and its pending closure underscores the peril of prioritizing autonomy over survival in any other form.

“I have been in meetings with board members who would rather see their institution closed than merge with another college,” said Peter Stokes, a higher education expert with Huron Consulting, which advises colleges and universities. “It’s not just a financial decision. It’s also a very emotional and often a very personal decision. Some board members will have had decades of commitment to the institution that they’re representing, so it can be very, very challenging.”

With other smaller schools in New England facing challenging financial outlooks similar to Hampshire’s, Stokes and other industry specialists urge administrators to learn from Hampshire’s experience and be more open to merging with a healthier institution.

Despite what may feel like a loss of identity or

SMALL COLLEGES, Page A14

Trump’s tastes take hold in a remade capital

Changes likely to outlast his time in Oval Office

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Taking a tour of our nation’s capital these days requires some flexibility. Most of the city’s landmarks still boast their customary glimmering marble structures, heroic statuary, and carefully manicured landscapes. But as of late, road closures, heavy machinery, and miles of fencing have encroached upon Washington’s iconography.

That creep of construction is emblematic of a President Trump-directed makeover being thrust upon the capital — one sealed with the promise that by the end of his second term, D.C. will be more beautiful than ever. While aesthetic merits are arguable, one conclusion is without doubt: if he is successful, Trump’s imprint on Washington

WASHINGTON, Page A8



MANUEL BALCE CENETA/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Equipment was placed at the White House for a mixed martial arts fight.

A family lost and a community shattered

Greenfield victims of Va. bus crash remembered for generosity, close ties

By Tonya Alanez and Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF
and Emily Spatz
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

GREENFIELD — Dmitri Doncev, a nurse at Holyoke Medical Center, was used to working the night shift, so driving through the night to his family member’s wedding in South Carolina was not an issue. He wanted

his two kids to get a chance to sleep.

The family set off late Thursday night, a niece of Dmitri’s said, in a packed car full of desserts that Dmitri’s wife, Ecaterina, had spent a week preparing. Within hours, the family was killed in a massive crash caused by a passenger bus that careered into a line of slowing cars on Interstate 95 in Virginia.

They were among the five people killed in the early morning crash that left dozens more injured, several of them in critical condition. Officials on Saturday evening identified Priscilla R. Mafalda, a 25-year-old from Worcester who was traveling in a different vehicle, as the fifth victim. Mafalda’s family could not be reached for comment.

Officials also said the driver of the bus, 48-year-old Jing Sheng Dong, has been charged with two counts of involuntary manslaughter, with additional charges pending.

Dong was ordered held without bond pending his discharge from the hospital and appearance in court.

Preliminary details suggest the bus, carrying 34 passengers and heading from New York City to Charlotte, N.C., failed to slow for traffic in a work zone and smashed into Mafalda’s vehicle, a Chevrolet Suburban. The impact then forced her vehicle into the Doncev family’s Acura SUV.

Brothers Dmitri and Iuri Doncev

CRASH, Page A15



A cyanotype reproduction of a photograph showing William Haney Jr. entering court in Boston on Jan. 5, where he pleaded not guilty to murder and animal cruelty charges stemming from the Jan. 3 attack that killed John Axelrod and his dog on the Commonwealth Avenue Mall. The original photograph was made by Globe photographer Pat Greenhouse.

A descent into chaos out of the blue

Medical records, family interviews, and police documents reveal months of escalating psychosis before a Back Bay attack that left an art collector dead

STORY BY LEA SKENE | GLOBE STAFF
PHOTOS BY ERIN CLARK | GLOBE STAFF

William Haney Jr. was losing his grip on reality.

After a change to his psychiatric medications last summer, he became increasingly distracted and fearful, consumed by paranoid delusions.

He thought dangerous people were coming for him: chasing him, hitting his car, beating him over the head.

It was largely unfamiliar territory for Haney, 43, whose schizophrenia had been adequately managed for decades.

His mother watched with growing concern. She tried to convince him he was safe and unharmed. She accompanied him to mental health appointments and raised concerns about his symptoms. His thoughts were jumbled and incoherent, she said. He often fixated on seemingly insignificant characters from his past, some perhaps imaginary, like high school classmates and a grocery store security guard.

HANEY, Page A12

An apparent meteor passing through the atmosphere just east of Boston caused a loud boom heard over multiple areas of Massachusetts. **Metro, B2.**

Senator Ed Markey secured an overwhelming endorsement for reelection at the Massachusetts Democratic Party convention. **Metro, B1.**

After years of being flat or down, Maine’s population has been rebounding as young people move there or return. **SundayTravel, N11.**

The evolution of media coverage of the WNBA has become quite a talking point, from injury reports to roster cuts to personal player relationships to locker-room access, writes Tara Sullivan. **Sports, C1.**

Chill ease

Sunday: Warmer, showers. High: 66-71. Low: 50-55.

Monday: More clouds than sun. High: 55-60. Low: 47-52.

Sunrise: 5:10 Sunset: 8:14

Complete report, **A22.**

Deaths, **A17-20.**

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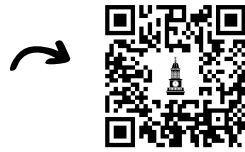
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